why, exactly, they supported a particular party, beyond the individual appeal of its leader. “I’ve covered eight elections in Israel, and this is by far the weirdest one,” said Dana Weiss, a presenter on Israel’s Channel 2. “Nobody has any idea what this is about.”

The confusion had helped to resurrect a number of politicians who had been left for dead. Yair Lapid, the dark horse of the 2013 election, had been performing poorly at the start of the campaign after two largely unproductive years as finance minister. In the final weeks of the campaign, however, he received a surge in support, even though he did not have any concrete policies.

Outside the Zionist Camp headquarters in Sderot there was a large poster of Amir Peretz, the former defense minister. He is deeply unpopular in Israel, seen as the man responsible for the disastrous strategy in the 2006 Lebanon war. He once managed to be photographed reviewing troops on the Golan Heights through a pair of binoculars with their lens caps on. But the Moroccan-born Peretz grew up in Sderot, and the party figured a personal appeal couldn’t hurt. “We’re hoping people will vote for us because of Amir,” admitted Melania Shkolnik, a campaigner.

Several parties were still struggling just to survive. Foreign Minister Avigdor Lieberman, once a kingmaker—“the real Frank Underwood of Israel politics”, one strategist quipped in reference to *House of Cards*—imploded amid a massive corruption scandal. Members of his Yisrael Beiteinu party resigned, or were hauled off by police. His frantic search for new candidates went as far as scooping up a 24-year-old student union president who had once posted on Facebook about “smelly Arabs.”

The ultra-Orthodox Shas, which caters to religious *mizrahi* Jews, faced its own crisis. Two men, Aryeh Deri and Eli Yishai, have long battled to lead the party. Yishai took over for a spell after his rival was convicted on corruption charges, but Deri regained control in 2012.

In December of 2014, shortly after the Knesset was dissolved, Yishai decided he’d had enough. He broke away from Shas to form a new party, Yachad, and announced a merger with Jewish Power, a far-right faction that counts among its candidates a onetime member of Kach, the banned Jewish terrorist organization. In a surreal moment, Israeli politics were roiled by a leaked video of Rabbi Ovadia Yosef, the vaunted spiritual leader of Shas. In an attack on Deri, in which he argued that he should not lead the party, he